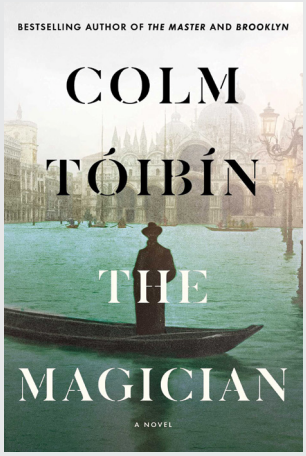
MY BEST OF 2021



MIRZA WAHEED
Author,
Tell Her Everything



THE MAGICIAN
Colm Tóibín
SCRIBNER
₹2,100; 512 pages

One of the books of the year for me is Colm Tóibín's magnificent novel, *The Magician*, a fictionalised biography of Thomas Mann. Toibin dramatises Mann's life and times in the most compelling fashion, giving us both a portrait of Mann the artist against the backdrop of 20th century Germany and that of a family man troubled by a lifelong struggle with his sexuality. It should be noted that Tóibín also draws a memorably vivid life sketch of Katia Mann. An epic novel.

DON'T FIGHT THIS FLIGHT

Written by **T.J. Newman,** a former flight attendant, *Falling* is a kind of blockbuster hijack drama that keeps you strapped in from the start



FALLING
by T.J. Newman
SIMON & SCHUSTER
₹599; 304 pages

You're flying a plane with 144 people on board, when you are told your family at home has been taken hostage. You have to choose: either crash a plane full of civilians and save your wife and two children, or save the plane and watch your family die. This is the dilemma thrust on Captain Bill Hoffman, a pilot with Coastal Airways when *Falling* opens. It's a promising premise and a turbo-charged read from debutant novelist and former flight attendant T.J. Newman.

Bill leaves home, after a cold exchange with his wife Carrie, to fly from LA to New York. Soon after take-off, he learns of his unthinkable Cornelian dilemma when the hostage-taker video calls him with his loved ones in captivity. Trying to alert anyone or asking for help could be calamitous, he is warned. But he manages to discreetly confide in his cabin colleague Jo, who then passes word along to her nephew Theo, an agent with the FBI.

The entire siege is being masterminded by Saman Khani, a disaffected Kurd with a political agenda. He hates Americans for destroying his homeland and family, and the crashed plane will be his big statement. The villain's origin story is interspersed in patches, and though the golden age of hijacking is long behind us, the disgruntlement is instantly recognisable.

The novel rotates primarily through four perspectives; Bill, his wife Carrie, the flight attendant Jo, and agent Theo. Chapters alternate in short bursts between air-borne action and on-ground chases, almost ready-for-Hollywood in their brisk pacing and snappy dialogue.

Newman wrote the book on cross-country flights and her knowledge of planes and people who work them is her biggest strength. Tetchy passengers feature alongside intrepid cabin crew and a deep knowledge of aviation's nuts and bolts. Also featured are the nuts and bolts of any self-respecting thriller. On steroids. Poison gas, explosions, injuries, the military, rogue agents, a mole on board. Since it's the US, there's an all-important baseball game thrown in for good measure. And since it's 2021, there's also an Instagram influencer, who, well, let's say, has some influence in the crisis situation.

Newman found a literary agent on her 42nd attempt, and the book has gone on to crack bestseller lists. *Falling* asks for a few hours of your time and a suspension of your disbelief; the book is pure, propulsive, plotting. The seat belt sign is never switched off. Did I feel like standing up and singing the Stars Spangled Banner by the end? I'll admit, a little bit. ■

–Bhavya Dore